

THE SOVIET DEBATE ON LITERATURE (1917-1925)

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INTRODUCTION

The Soviet Union represents the first large scale attempt at producing social changes in accordance with a preconceived plan. The gigantic proportions of the problem and the precariously narrow margin between failure and success have led those in charge of the implementation of the plan to the conclusion that only the complete mobilization of all the material and spiritual resources available would ensure the fulfilment of the plan.

Whatever critics may say about the nature of art, it cannot be denied that art has in all times been a powerful stimulant to action. From the legends of the ancient Greeks to the most personal and introspective paintings of a modern French cubist, art "infects" the minds of those who come into contact with it. It is in this sense that art influences reality. Institutions in all ages and periods have called upon artists to aid them in the attainment of their objectives. The most famous example of this is the Catholic Church, which realized very early the practical uses of art. Similarly the Soviets have insisted that art be in harmony with the major objective of the state: the rapid achievement of the communistic society.

The methods employed for effecting this demand have varied from pre-publication censorship to praise in literary reviews, from exile of artists to awards of prizes, medals, and titles to those whose work is felt to be of special utility. By these methods it proved relatively easy to keep artists in line.

To determine, however, what the correct policy should be, has been found to be much more difficult. In order to satisfy all requirements no single consistent policy could be adopted, rather was it found necessary to change, frequently very abruptly, the official policy as conditions demanded. Viewed in this light Zhdanov's

recent censure (August 1946) of certain Soviet writers and of the policies of the writer organizations is but another stage in adjusting the official policies to the exigencies of the moment.

The first debate on literature in the Soviet state took place in the years of the Civil War and the NEP. The Soviet government at that time was faced by so many pressing problems, each of which threatened its very existence, that it had no time to concentrate on problems of art under the dictatorship of the proletariat. It was therefore still permissible to discuss the problem with a maximum of freedom. It was even questioned whether there should be any conscious direction of art at all. The debate exhibited many of the features which are characteristic of debates carried on in the Soviet Union.

The most characteristic of these is the acceptance of Marxism by all disputants. In none of the debates, to my knowledge, has it been suggested that Marxism needed revision or amplification on the basis of the experience of the Soviet state, other than those made by Lenin and Stalin. On the contrary, each disputant claimed to possess the correct interpretation of Marx's thoughts and charged his opponents with falsifying, distorting, vulgarizing and emasculating the doctrine.

This absolute acceptance of the doctrine is perhaps also one of the reasons why the debate on literature has continued for over a quarter of a century without producing anything more fundamental than decisions by official bodies which no sooner than adopted are disregarded in practice and soon have to be reversed and revised by new official decisions.

It is the purpose of this essay to survey the first stage of the debate on literature (1917 to 1925). Particular emphasis has been placed on the more extreme advocates of absolute control of literature by the Party because it was felt that in the long run their counsel has been more influential in shaping official Party policies than that of any other group. Although the Party greatly modified their theories and even went on record twice as opposed to them, these ideas have exercised

a profound influence on all thinking which has been done in the Soviet Union about literature and the state.

How powerful this influence is can be seen when one compares Zhdanov's speech of August 1946 with the manifestos of the October group. It is no accident either that one of the results of the shake-up occasioned by Zhdanov's speech was the appointment of Fadeev as president of the Soviet Writers' Union. Fadeev was one of the leaders among the younger generation of the Onguardists and was closely identified with the demand for complete Party control of literature. It would almost seem that the attitude of the Party of 1946 has returned to where it was in 1929, the zenith of the influence and power of the most extreme advocates of complete control.

It must be pointed out here that a brief essay like this cannot hope to give a full picture of developments and that judgments based on the material presented here would be based on incomplete evidence, as I was forced to limit myself to particular aspects of Soviet literature.

CHAPTER I

THE HISTORICAL AND IDEOLOGICAL BACKGROUND

The Intelligentsia after the Revolution

Of all the classes of Russia the intelligentsia was most immediately and profoundly affected by the October Revolution and by the events which followed in its wake. An important segment of the old intelligentsia either emigrated or was wiped out physically. Those who survived and remained in Russia lived in unbelievably difficult material circumstances. Many of them regarded the new order of things with grave reservations if not with open hostility. The Bolsheviks, for their part, saw in the intelligentsia a potentially dangerous element and made its life even more difficult by a host of legal and extra-legal restrictions.

Under such conditions the old intelligentsia could not function properly and was supplanted by a group of new men and women. This process can be observed in all spheres of human endeavor which are in the province of the intelligentsia, from factory management to metaphysics. It manifested itself particularly clearly in literature.

With few exceptions the men who had won literary reputations before the first World War have little importance in post-revolutionary Russian literature. Even those artists who welcomed the Revolution whole-heartedly soon discovered that they were not part of it, and that they had failed to grasp its true nature.

Even Briusov, who had "accepted" the Revolution not passively, not contemplatively, not like a well-wishing observer on the side lines; Briusov, who had become a Communist, did not create anything artistically significant: he felt the unsuitability of the old poetic means and

methods of work and tried to "re-learn"; but this led only to his losing his characteristic timbre, because he had not organically absorbed the new shades and intonations.¹

During the difficult years of the Civil War the literary life of the country was at a practical standstill. Whatever literary activity there was, was confined to a few irregularly appearing literary magazines, to literature printed in the periodicals of the Party and the Soviets, and finally to the activities in a few taverns frequented by the Bohemia of Moscow and Petrograd. It is interesting and, perhaps, not very surprising in view of the ideological implications of the events of those days that a great part of the space in these literary magazines was devoted to the discussion of theoretical problems. It was in this early period that many of the problems which Soviet critics and writers have debated ever since were first raised.

The Futurists

The fact that the proletariat had proclaimed its dictatorship over the state, prompted many literary groups to claim the same position over literature. In sonorous pronouncements the many literary factions of the time declared that their theories were the only ones in conformity with the principles of a proletarian state and that therefore their art was the art of the proletariat.

Although the Soviets did not commit themselves to the support of any single literary group, they did encourage certain groups of writers more than others. The group which first gained a measure of official support were the Futurists.

In the official organ of the Commissariat for Education The Art of the Commune, they proclaimed their doctrines, which briefly were as follows:

1. The art of the past is to be rejected because it was created for the

1. A. Lezhnev, "Khudozhestvennaia literatura", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, VII, N27, (Moscow, October-November 1927), p. 91.

enjoyment of an oppressor class. The proletariat has no use for it.

Their leader Maiakovskii sang in those days:

Arrayed are your cannon near the woods,/ Impervious to
White Guards' amenities./ But why is not Pushkin attacked?/
And the other classic generals?¹

2. Art should not attempt to imitate nature. Nature is perfect, and an artist trying to create things which are found in nature only disfigures them. Instead the artist should create things of beauty hitherto unseen. These new creations must also have a utilitarian value.

In a speech in 1918 Maiakovskii declared:

We need a "rye" art, "rye" words, "rye" deeds. The art of the present is useless. All the old objects and landscapes speak only of the prattle of the rich and the bourgeois. It is sad that artists waste their talents upon such useless things. Art must be concentrated not in dead temples-museums, but everywhere: on the streets, on the street cars, in the factories, in the work shops and in the workers' sections (of the cities).²

3. Artists should employ their talents and skills with definite political and social goals in mind; e.g. the establishment of socialism in Russia. Maiakovskii's work, which in those years consisted almost exclusively of morale-building slogans, agitational verse, and jingles for placards, is a good example of what the Futurists meant when they called upon the artist to go "out into the street".

4. Futurism is the art of the proletariat and, therefore, should be permitted to establish its dictatorship over all Soviet art.

The Soviet leadership which at first had welcomed the Futurists and had given them a number of privileges, such as newsprint for their own newspaper

1. As quoted in A. Kaun, Soviet Poets and Poetry. (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1943), p. 40.

2. Iskustvo komuny No. 1 (Petrograd, 1918), as quoted in "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik No. 7 (Moscow, July 1937), p. 136.

Newspaper of the Futurists and control over the official organ of the Commissariat for Education The Art of the Commune, soon became cool towards them. Already in the fourth issue of The Art of the Commune the Commissar for Education Lunacharskii published a letter in which he severely criticized the pretensions of the Futurists. In his letter to the editor Lunacharskii wrote:

Two features in the young face of this newspaper in whose columns this letter is printed somewhat frighten (me): the destructive inclinations with regard to the past, and the tendency to speak in the name of the state power when speaking in the name of a certain school.¹

Lunacharskii continued that the function of the Commissariat for Education was to conserve as much of the old art as possible, and that, therefore, the official organ of the Commissariat could not continue "to picture all artistic achievement from Adam to Maiakovskii as a heap of rubbish subject to destruction".² He rejected most decisively the aspiration of the Futurists to a dictatorship over Soviet art:

It would be a misfortune if the artist-innovators were to consider themselves wholly as a governmental school of art, as agents of an official art which, though revolutionary, would nonetheless be dictated from above.³

The growing coolness of the state towards the Futurists as well as the oft-cited fact that Futurism proved incapable of producing works of lasting artistic merit (which perhaps should be more properly blamed on the material and spiritual conditions prevailing at the time than on the sterility of the Futurist doctrine) caused their influence to subside, until at the end of the Civil War Futurism was but another literary group.

1. A. V. Lunacharskii, "Lozhka protivoiadiia", as quoted ibid., p. 139.

2. ibid., p. 140.

3. ibid.

The Proletcult

The Proletcult had been founded in the period between the February and the October revolutions. The theories of the movement had been formulated in their main outlines already before the first World War by A. A. Bogdanov (pseudonym of A. Malinovskii), an unusual and colorful personality.

Bogdanov held that there were three separate roads to socialism: the political, the economic, and the cultural. To achieve complete and real liberation the proletariat must be victorious in all three spheres. Thus it is not enough for the proletariat to gain control of the state machinery, it must also master the old culture (which in Bogdanov's terminology included technology as well as the arts) and create a new, proletarian culture.

This new culture must be absolutely proletarian. Therefore the organization charged with its creation must, like the Communist Party and the trade unions, be independent of other organs of the dictatorship of the proletariat, for, as a later history of Soviet literature expressed it,

. . . . the Soviets as organs of the state power represent something mixed; because in the Soviets participate not only workers, but also peasants, white collar workers, and artisans. Consequently the Soviet apparatus as such cannot carry out the building of a new, purely proletarian culture.¹

Quite in agreement with other Marxists Bogdanov held that art is a tool for the organization of classes. Art which is not proletarian exerts, therefore, an undesirable influence on the consciousness of the proletariat as it does not educate the masses for communism.

Nevertheless Bogdanov felt that the rise of the proletariat as a ruling class ". . . . does not at all mean a simple break with all the rich culture of the old world. No, the proletariat is the legal heir of all its valuable conquests,

1. M. Brodskii-Krasnov and V. Druzin, Kratkii ocherk istorii russkoi literatury XIX i XX vekov (Saratov: OGIZ RSFSR, 1931), p. 84

spiritual as well as material; this heritage it neither can nor must renounce."¹

Furthermore the emotions which great art evokes are not wholly determined by the class environment which moulded its creator. There is in great art an element which affects all human beings regardless of their class allegiance.

Thus, speaking of a statue of Venus, Bogdanov wrote:

The gods have died. The goddess has ceased to organize her former collective; however, people have felt the great organizing force of the statue, they have felt the beautiful. And from the moment that people behold it, they are forever bound to one another by something in common.²

Other theoreticians elaborated on this basic theory. Fundamentally, however, it remained unchanged until 1920, when, upon Lenin's personal insistence, a Proletcult convention was forced to adopt certain important modifications of its program.³

The creation of the new culture was to be the task of the workshops which the Proletcult organized throughout the country. The activities of these studios as well as the conditions under which Russian artists lived and worked are well described in a paragraph from a report on the activities of the Petrograd Proletcult:

In the literary section during the months of September and October the regular activities were continued. Study periods were conducted four times a week. Lectures were read on the subject of versification, on the theory of literature, on the history of literature, on the theory of the drama, and on the history of material culture. Furthermore, comrade Chukovskii read lectures on Nekrasov, Gor'kii, and Walt Whitman. Lectures of comrade A. M. Gor'kii were postponed temporarily because of his illness. At the present time almost all proletarian poets are at the front. Enrollment of new members continues.⁴

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1. As quoted by V. Polonskii, "Literaturnoe dvizhenie oktiabr'skogo desiatiletiia," Pechat' i revoliutsiia, VII, No. 7 (Moscow, October-November 1927), p. 34.
 2. ibid., p. 35.
 3. cf. pp. 9-ff. *infra*.
 4. Report in journal Griadushchee No.7-8, (1919), as quoted in "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let," Literaturnyi kritik, No. 7 (Moscow, July 1937) p.158.

The theoreticians hoped that by offering education to proletarians who showed interest in the arts, they would be able to train new artists as well as a public for them, thus laying the basis for a new proletarian culture. However, influential members of the Party soon expressed doubts as to the efficacy of this method. Already in the middle of 1919 Bukharin published an article in Pravda in which he expressed his doubts whether a culture could be developed "by laboratory methods". In the same article he also attacked the demands of the Proletcult for independence from other organs of the state.¹ The Proletcult reacted to this article by claiming the disagreement between their position and that of Bukharin was due to a misunderstanding on Bukharin's part and continued to insist upon independence from organs of the Soviet state.

It was not until the fall of 1920 that Lenin entered into the controversy and forced a radical change in the Proletcult program. In a speech to a convention of the Comsomol Lenin said:

Proletarian culture is not something that jumps out from somewhere; it is not an invention of people who call themselves specialists on proletarian art. All this is pure rubbish. Proletarian culture must come forth as a result of a normal development of those stores of knowledge which humanity has created under the yoke of capitalist society, feudal society, and bureaucratic society.²

On Proletcult demands for independence from state organs Lenin took a strongly negative stand. When at the first convention of the Proletcult (Moscow, October 2 - 12, 1920) Lunacharskii made a speech in which he supported these demands, albeit with certain qualifications, Lenin immediately drafted a resolution and ordered the Party active in the convention to vote for its adoption, thus assuring its passage. The resolution reiterated the idea that a

1. As quoted by Polonskii, op. cit., p. 34.

2. V. I. Lenin, Sochineniia, Vol. XXV, (Moscow, 1931), p. 387. As quoted in "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik, No. 8, (Moscow, August 1937), p. 102.

proletarian culture can develop only gradually and in accordance with certain laws from the cultural heritage of the past. In its final paragraph, Lenin wrote:

. . . . the all-Russian convention of the Proletcult rejects in the most decisive manner as theoretically incorrect and as practically harmful all attempts to invent a special culture of its own, to lock itself up in its individual organizations, to fix the limits of the spheres of work of the Commissariat for Education and the Proletcult, etc., or to establish "autonomy" of the Proletcult within the organs of the Commissariat for Education, etc. On the contrary, the convention considers it an unconditional duty of all organizations of the Proletcult to consider themselves wholly as supporting organs of the net of organs of the Commissariat of Education, and to accomplish their tasks under the common leadership of the Soviet power (in particular the Commissariat of Education) and the Russian Communist Party (Bolsheviks) as an integral part of the tasks of the dictatorship of the proletariat.

This resolution was followed by the publication of a letter of the Central Committee of the Communist Party to local officers of the Proletcult. The letter contained detailed directives for the implementation of the resolution cited above. All organs of the Proletcult on all levels were subordinated to corresponding organs of the Commissariat of Education. However the Commissariat was ordered to create and maintain conditions which would secure to proletarians opportunities for creative work. The letter explained to local officers of the Proletcult that the demands for independence had been justified in the pre-October period, for then it was a question of independence from a bourgeois government. After the Revolution such independence was neither desirable, nor justifiable. Autonomy could only be justified in matters of creative work. This was safeguarded by the instructions of the Central Committee. The letter ended by blaming bourgeois intellectuals (among them the Futurists) in the Proletcult and in the Commissariat of Education for the mistakes made.²

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1. V.I. Lenin, Sochineniia, Vol. XXV, (Moscow, 1931), p. 410. As quoted in "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik, No. 8 (Moscow, Aug. 1937).
 2. ibid, pp. 105-6, Pravda, Dec. 1, 1920 (as quoted) -- "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik, No. 8 (Moscow, Aug. 1937), p. 105-6.

As a result of this resolution Bogdanov was removed from his post as head of the Proletcult, and his place was taken by V. F. Pletnev. Pletnev attempted to purge the Proletcult of all elements of "Bogdanovism" and bring its ideology closer to the views expressed by Lenin. However the changes which Pletnev made and the new theories he proclaimed failed to satisfy Lenin.

After Lenin's death an article by Pletnev heavily supplied with sarcastic marginalia was found among Lenin's papers. The many high-sounding phrases of Pletnev attracted Lenin's particular attention. For example, when Pletnev wrote: "The proletarian artist will be at one and the same time an artist and a worker", Lenin wrote: "Nonsense!" on the margin.¹

In October, 1922, an article by I. A. Iakovlev appeared in Pravda in which the "utopian" qualities of Pletnev's views were sharply attacked.² According to Bukharin this article had been inspired by Lenin. Bukharin told a meeting of the Central Committee in February 1925 that he, in his capacity as editor in chief of Pravda had protested against the sharp tone of the article as first submitted and had threatened to publish a rebuttal in the following issue if the article were not modified. Thereupon the article was toned down in deference to Bukharin's demands.³

Regardless of all efforts to revive it and to bring its theories in line with the policies of the Communist Party, the Proletcult never recovered its influence. It continued to exist in a semi-moribund state until the dissolution of all literary factions in April 1932.

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1. The complete article by Pletnev, first published in Pravda of September 27, 1922, as well as Lenin's marginal comments are reprinted in "Khronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik, No. 9 (Moscow, Sept. 1937), pp. 79-88.
 2. The complete article by Iakovlev, first published in Pravda of October 24 and 25, 1922, is reprinted ibid., 95-105.
 3. N. Bukharin, "Proletariat i voprosy khudozhestvennoi politiki", Krasnaia nov', No. 4 (Moscow, May 1925), 263-272.

The Smithy

In Pravda of February 5, 1920 there appeared a notice signed by several writers who were members of the Moscow Proletcult announcing their withdrawal from that organization. These writers, among whom there were several whose works had been published by Gor'kii before the Revolution, were proletarians or of proletarian ancestry. Because of this they felt that they alone would be able to reflect the true aspirations of the working class and to produce a proletarian art.

The Smithy developed a rather complete theory of art which resembled in some aspects that of the Proletcult. However, because the members of the group were actual poets and novelists, while the Proletcult was led by theoreticians, the theories of the Smiths seem more in touch with reality than those of the Proletcult. When the Smiths talk of the traits of proletarian literature they have in mind something very specific, namely the work of the members of their group. Whether they were right in generalizing about proletarian literature from the relatively few examples at hand is, of course, open to debate.

The following traits were postulated as the trade mark of proletarian literature:¹

1. A conscious attitude towards the environment
Proletarian literature begins where the unconscious attitude of the proletariat towards the world ends.

2. the labor element, work, realization of its power and the joy created by this realization.
The main thing that unites proletarian writers is the feeling for work, the realization that only by and through work the ideal is to be achieved, that work is the criterion of justice and of equality. They (proletarian writers - M.H.) impart labor processes even to the phenomena of nature. The moon, the trills of the nightingale, the stars, the sun, the cuckoo, everything suggests images of work.

1. The following passages are quoted from N. Liashko "Osnovnye otlichitel'nye priznaki proletarskoi literatury", Kuznitsa (Moscow, Oct. 1922) as reprinted in N. L. Brodskii et al., ed. Literaturnye manifesty (Moscow, Federatsiia 1929), pp. 152-158.

3. Machinism, the metallic theme.

The contemporary backward machine as an instrument of exploitation reduces the proletarian to the role of an automaton; on the other hand it points to the machine of the future: the universal machine, the machine --as friend.

Proletarian writers penetrate into the spirit of metals, into their history, into their intimate world and character.

4. Collectivism and planetarity.

"We" in proletarian literature forces out "I", but this does not lead to what various types of innovators pass off as "collective creation". The personality is free; before it lies a wide field for action -- it is in harmony with the collective in the most fundamental things, but reflects its own collective spirit in its distinct manner.

Liashko is not clear on the meaning of the term "planetarity" (planetarnost').

He talks of the unity of the workers everywhere in the world which grows out of the common experience of "grasping the hammer". According to one critic, however,

The poets of The Smithy accepted the Revolution as a revolution of planetary, cosmic dimension. The revolution on earth was, in their opinion, but a moment in the universal revolution.¹

The Smiths were very specific about the form of the new proletarian art:

"Proletarian art is art which by its very nature is an art of the large canvas, of the grand style -- a monumental art."²

This statement has been often quoted derisively by Soviet opponents of The Smithy. Nonetheless the officially sponsored art of the Soviet Union shows a definite tendency towards the epic, the monumental, "the large canvas"; for example, the plans for the Palace of the Soviets with its gigantic Lenin statue, the officially

1. M. Brodskii-Krasnov, op. cit., p. 86.

The "cosmism" of the Smiths is in the opinion of Voronskii (cf. his article in Krasnaia nov', No. 3 (Moscow, 1923, 215-227) just another form of the monism of Mach and Avenarius. This is very significant in view of the fact that Gor'kii, the mentor of many of the Smiths, was at one time deeply influenced by the ideas of these philosophers. His school in Capri became a center of monist philosophical thought. This provoked the disapproval of Lenin, who in Materialism and Empirio-Criticism attacked it as a deviation from orthodox Marxism. On the role of Bogdanov and Lunacharskii in this controversy see B. Wolfe, "Lenin as a Philosopher", Partisan Review, XIV, (1947), pp. 396-413.

2. As quoted in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit. p. 165.

recognized masterpiece of Soviet literature "The Quiet Don" by Sholokhov, the later films like "Ivan the Terrible", "Peter", "Alexander Nevskii" and "Chapaev", Shostakovich's Seventh Symphony.

The attitude of the Smiths towards the cultural heritage is somewhat self-contradictory. In the article quoted above Liashko writes:

The proletarian writers admire that part of the literary heritage which contains historically essential spiritual values. To this part belongs the so-called classical literature, which has recorded the growth and the power of the social forces which have succeeded one another in the historical arena.¹

It was, however, one of the most prominent members of the group who expressed very different views:

In the name of our to-morrow/ We shall burn Raphael,/ We shall destroy the museums,/ We shall trample the flowers of art²

Very much like the Proletcult the Smiths claimed to be "the only association standing wholly on the program of the revolutionary vanguard of the working class and the Russian Communist Party".³

Despite this protestation of loyalty to the party the Smiths underwent a very serious ideological crisis when the Party adopted the New Economic Policy. This retreat was not acceptable to the most radical of the Smiths. The question of the "acceptance" of the NEP was debated long and heatedly. It resulted in the resignation of two of the Smiths -- Gerasimov and Kirillov -- from the party, and in the ultimate founding of new organizations of proletarian writers who accepted the NEP.

The fact that The Smithy was composed mainly of established writers seems to have made them somewhat insensitive to the needs of the younger generation of writers.

1. As quoted ibid., pp. 157-158.

2. From a poem by V. Kirillov as quoted in M. Brodskii-Krasnov, op. cit., p. 86.

3. As quoted by N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., p. 166.

Although I could not assemble documentary evidence on this charge, its frequent repetition by opponents of the group would lead me to believe that it was at least partially true.

Not commanding the best literary talent of the period -- the greatest artists of the period were the non-proletarian "fellow-travellers" whom The Smithy decried as bourgeois -- nor developing writers of note among its younger members, The Smithy soon lost a great deal of its importance. By 1924 it had lost control of the All-Russian Association of Proletarian Writers (VAPP), in the founding of which the Smiths had been instrumental.

CHAPTER II

THE ONGUARDISTS

Pre-history

One of the most characteristic traits of Soviet intellectual life has been the struggle for an orthodox interpretation of the Party line. The official attitude of the Party is never quite the same thing to all Party members. Thus arises the phenomenon that various groups and factions claim to be the only correct and orthodox interpreters of the decisions of the central organs. It is under the guise of this "quarrel of believers" that differences in the Party are fought out. Periodically an authoritative statement, e.g. a resolution by the Central Committee or a speech by a member of the Politbureau, puts an end to these discussions. The quarrels are then resumed in somewhat modified form.

As we have seen in the preceding chapter, despite the strict discipline upon which the Communist Party has always insisted, its policies as adopted by the competent organs were not always accepted by the entire membership. This was especially true in the case of the adoption of the NEP. The Smiths did not want to accept the NEP, which they felt was a violation of the basic principles for which they had fought the Revolution.

There were others, however, who felt that the retreat ordered by the leadership was a wise step. These were mainly young men who had grown up in the days of the Civil War. To them opposition to decisions of the Party was unthinkable. They, therefore, organized new groups which whole-heartedly supported the Party leadership.

It is significant that the strongly pronounced mystical tendencies of the Smiths were further intensified with the change in the group's attitude towards the

policies of the regime. For an orthodox Communist, mysticism is an improper way of viewing the world; in his eyes it is usually a camouflage for reaction. The new groups reacted against the non-realistic art of the Smiths as another deviation from orthodox revolutionary views.

The first of these new groups was The Workers' Spring (Rabochaia vesna). All the members of this organization were newcomers to literature, and most of them never became professional writers, but remained factory workers. Their aim was, as they said in a forward to a collection of their work,

. . . . to give to the broad masses of workers in the factories, plants and workshops a number of songs and tales which have poured forth from under the pens of exactly such proletarians as the readers themselves are and which reflect the proper state of mind of these masses and their creative work processes.¹

Although they still regarded the Smiths as their masters, they were quite a different type of men, less educated, less philosophical: they were proletarians who wrote poetry and not poets who happened to be of proletarian origin.

At about the same time several writers who were members of the Communist Youth League (Komsomol) founded the group The Young Guard (Molodaia gvardiia). Among the members of this group were some of the men who were slated to play a very important role in subsequent developments: e.g., the poet Bezymenskii, the novelist Libedinskii, and the critic Averbakh.

In one of their first public statements they protested against the unrealistic conceptions of the Smiths, against their "flying away into the clouds". Their battle cry was a poem of Bezymenskii:

To the sun!/ Enough of planets being hurled about like snowballs!/
. . . . only he is on our way,/ who in every trifle/ can find a world
revolution!²

1. As quoted in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., p. 178.

2. As quoted in M. B., "Molodaia gvardiia," Na literaturnom postu, No. 8 (Moscow, 1927), p. 83.

Nevertheless the members of this group still maintained ties with The Smithy and in some respect considered themselves junior partners of the latter.

On October 7, 1922 a number of writers, among whom were Bezymenskii, Zharov, and Malashkin, published a letter in which they announced their withdrawal from The Smithy and the forming of a new group October (Oktiabr'). This group provided the nucleus for various organizations of proletarian writers and became the standard bearer of radical Marxist literary doctrines. Its history is intimately interwoven with the history of Soviet literature until 1932. Its doctrines, which were a crystallization of the most extreme views held by various Marxist critics, became the dogma of Soviet literature during the first Five Year Plan and seem to have retained a great deal of their importance to the present despite their official condemnation by the Central Committee of the Communist Party.

Some months later, in March, 1923, on the initiative of the group The Workers' Spring a conference of proletarian writers in Moscow was called. The Smithy was not represented at the conference; on the other hand the other two proletarian groups of writers sent their representatives. Members of The Workers' Spring proposed the formation of a Moscow association of proletarian writers. The other groups were not ready for the step at the time. However, a few months later such an association was actually founded. It will hereafter be referred to by its initials MAPP.

In June, 1923, the first number of the critical review of the October group On Guard (Na postu) made its appearance. Until its closing by official order in the spring of 1925 the review attacked with unexampled violence all those who deviated from or contested the views of the October group. The bitterness with which the controversy was conducted can hardly be understood by anyone who is not acquainted with the dominant tones of Russian literary criticism from Belinskii's famous "Letter to Gogol" to the present. The Soviet critic Polonskii wrote about this debate:

People proffered against each other accusations which did not lead to judicial proceedings only because it was thought that in literary controversies

everything was permissible. Fellow-writers treated each other as if they were class enemies.¹

Theories and Manifestoes

At the base of the theories of the October group lay a particular interpretation of the doctrines of Marx. Marx considered art as a part of the "super-structure". In his view, art was determined by the economic conditions prevailing during a certain period:

We set out from real active men, and on the basis of their real life-process we demonstrate the development of the ideological reflexes and echoes of this life-process. The phantoms formed in the human brain are necessarily sublimates of their material life-process, which is empirically verifiable and bound to material premises. Morality, metaphysics, religion, all the rest of ideology and their corresponding forms of consciousness, thus no longer retain the semblance of independence. They have no history, no development, but men developing their material production and their material intercourse, alter, along with this, their real existence, their thinking and the products of their thinking.²

The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas.³

Half a century after these sentences were written Engels modified the theory in the following manner:

Political, legal, philosophical, literary, artistic, etc. development is grounded upon economic development. But all of them react, conjointly and separately, one upon another and upon the economic foundation.⁴

From these premises the theoreticians of many Marxist groups reasoned, it would seem, logically that art is a "tool for the organization of the consciousness of a class" and that all art in the proletarian state must be consciously proletarian. Art which has a different class basis is not only undesirable, it is positively harmful. In the writings of the theoreticians of the group October these

1. V. Polonskii, op. cit., p. 72.

2. K. Marx and F. Engels, The German Ideology, (New York, Intern. Pub., 1939,) pp. 14f.

3. ibid., p. 39.

4. Letter to Starkenburg (Jan. 25, 1894) as quoted in F.J. Klingender, Marxism and Modern Art, (New York, Intern. Pub., 1946).

ideas received their most radical and logically extreme formulation.

In a resolution adopted by the first Moscow conference of proletarian writers the following basic tenets were enunciated:

In a class society, literature as well as other things serve the objectives of a certain class, and only through the class -- the whole of humanity In the process of extending and strengthening the dictatorship of the proletariat and of hastening the creation of a communistic society, proletarian literature, while remaining profoundly class literature, not only organizes the psyche and the consciousness of the working class, but also influences other strata of society, thereby removing the last ground from under the feet of bourgeois literature Only their social significance can serve as the basic criterion for the evaluation of a literary tendency or of a literary phenomenon. Only that literature is socially useful in our time which organizes the psyche and the consciousness of the readers on the side of the ultimate objectives of the proletariat as the creator of the communistic society, i.e. proletarian literature. Any other literature, influencing the reader differently, collaborates to a certain extent in the resurrection of bourgeois or petty bourgeois ideology.¹

The resolution divides writers into three categories: 1) overtly bourgeois and counter-revolutionary, like Bunin and Akhmatova, 2) petty bourgeois, like the writers united in The Serapion Brotherhood, who accept the Revolution but "reflect it in a crooked mirror", 3) proletarian writers.

With respect to the first (bourgeois) group the resolution states: "This literature is a detachment of the class opponents of the proletariat, and its activity in Soviet Russia cannot be justified by anything from the point of view of the proletariat!"²

In regard to the second (petty-bourgeois) group the resolution advocates the following policy:

. . . . they cannot have any positive educational significance for the working class. At the same time they are capable of playing a certain role in the matter of dulling the enmity toward the Revolution from the side of the wavering petty bourgeois circles and of inculcating in the

1. As quoted in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., p. 187. (Italics are mine. The italicized phrase is usually considered as the group's definition of proletarian literature.)

2. ibid.

consciousness of these circles the thoughts of the necessity of a real cooperation with the ruling proletariat.¹

The resolution envisions the following role for proletarian literature:

. . . . considering that with the passage of time proletarian literature will become the only serious force in the field of the artistic word, it is necessary to recognize that already now the interests of the ideological front demand the acquisition by proletarian literature of the directing influence in the basic organs of the press.²

Unlike the Proletcult the October group did not include the demand for independence from the Party in its claim for hegemony in the field of literature. The group wanted to be a tool of the Party for the realization of the dictatorship of the proletariat over literature. To this task they brought an ardent conviction that they were on the right track and an unusual seriousness and determination to get the work done.

While engaged in this work we shall stand firmly on guard over a strong and clear Communist ideology in proletarian literature. In view of the revival, since the beginning of the NEP, of the activity of bourgeois literary groups, all ideological doubts are absolutely inadmissible, and we shall make a point of bringing them to light.³

The group also offered a fairly specific set of suggestions on the form of a proletarian art. Although many of the concrete recommendations sound quite naive, they are extremely important as they continue to reappear in Soviet literary criticism with surprising regularity.

The group postulated the primacy of content over form: "The content and the form are dialectical antitheses: the content determines the form and is formulated artistically by the latter."⁴ Hence it rejected experimentation in form and proclaimed formalistic experiments a sign of bourgeois decadence.

1. ibid.

2. ibid.

3. From the editorial manifesto of the review On Guard, originally published in Na postu, No. 1 (Moscow, June, 1923), as quoted in G. Reavey and M. Slonim, Soviet Literature, (New York: Covici-Friede, 1934), p. 405.

4. As quoted in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., p. 184.

Very much like the Smiths, October talked of the epic, monumental form of the proletarian art. It called upon artists to turn from the lyricism which prevailed at that period to an "epic and dramatic" approach to the material. The artist should pay more attention to his immediate surroundings and direct his creative energies into definite socially useful channels. Libedinskii, a member of the group and himself of novelist of some importance, outlined the topics which proletarian writers should treat. Almost without exceptions these topics concern the recent past or the present; e.g. the building of a socialist economy, the struggle of the proletariat with the bourgeoisie, the Civil War, and the decomposition of the old mores under the impact of the new life.¹

The Practice

Such was the theory. It was created with the aim of achieving a communist society in the most direct and expeditious manner possible. The practical steps of the group were in keeping with this theory. They, too, were dictated by a basic desire to achieve the ideal. This fact must always be kept in mind when evaluating the activities of the group.

Organizational Activities

Like the Party the October group attempted to set up a strict discipline among its members. Paragraph three of the agreement between MAPP and its Leningrad counterpart states:

Both associations oblige their members to carry out the promulgated line The administrations will take the most severe measures (including expulsion) against members who fail to carry out the directives of their respective administrations.²

1. I. U. Libedinskii, "Temy, kotorye zhduť svoikh avtorov," Na postu, No. 1 (Moscow, June, 1923,) as quoted in full in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit. pp. 189-193.

2. As quoted in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., p. 200.

The struggle was to be carried on in a military fashion, and objectives to be conquered were to be set up by the high command:

The administrations of the associations designate those organs of the press, journals and publishing houses which must be conquered, or in which it is necessary to take measures to guarantee the correct line, or whose appearance must be changed¹

In the coming struggle the need for allies was also foreseen. Therefore the association allied itself with other groups of writers, proletarian as well as non-proletarian. The most important allies were the reformed Futurists, whose organization was LEF (Left front), and the Constructivists, a group of avant garde artists which counted among its members Il'ia Selvinskii and Vera Inber. Neither the Futurists nor the Constructivists had ideologies which agreed with that of the October group. However, that, apparently, did not matter to the contracting parties.

The pact with LEF, concluded in November, 1923, pointed to the dangers of infecting the youth and the proletarian intelligentsia with the ideas of the bourgeoisie. In order to combat this danger better, it is necessary for all "proletarian and truly revolutionary literary organizations" to join forces. The contracting parties agreed to

. . . . enter as organizations into agreements with publishing enterprises and organs of the press and struggle against the predominance of reactionary and sham fellow-traveller groups in these organizations, by making their participation conditional upon these groups being deprived of their dominating influence.²

The contracting parties agreed also to abstain from mutual polemics; however they would not stop all discussion and professional criticism of one another.

The final and, in my opinion, extremely important paragraph states that measures will be worked out which will improve the material condition and protect the professional interests of the members of the groups. In the Russia of the NEP, which had very few safeguards against pirating literary production and which was excluded

1. "Agreement between MAPP and LEF", as quoted in full in N. L. Brodskii, op. cit., pp. 244-247.

2. ibid.

from the international copy-right conventions, the economic conditions of writers were very bad. The efforts of the associations of proletarian writers on this score were a very strong point in their favor in campaigning for new members.

One of the first objectives of the October group was to gain control of the All-Russian Association of Proletarian Writers (VAPP), which had been founded on the initiative of the Smiths and had become moribund as a result of the ideological difficulties in which the Smiths found themselves after the promulgation of the NEP. This objective was easily conquered, for the October group controlled a majority of the votes in the VAPP. They could count also on the support of the organization with which they had entered into agreements. Thus when at the instance of the October group a congress of VAPP was called in May, 1924, the congress elected a new administration which was completely in favor of the objectives of the group, as well as passed a resolution adopting the manifesto of the October group as the literary platform of VAPP. Although the group suffered a serious setback soon thereafter, it maintained its hold over VAPP. This enabled them to regain their previous positions within less than two years after their official condemnation by the Party.

Literary Criticism

In line with the manifesto of the October group the basic demand of the critics of the group was "the liberation of Soviet literature from the hegemony of bourgeois and petty bourgeois writers."

It has been remarked by the critic Voronskii, who was one of the main opponents of October and the target of its bitterest campaign, that this demand was but another phase of the struggle against the non-proletarian specialist which was taking place in Soviet Russia until the end of the first Five Year Plan. The Onguardists considered the non-proletarian writer a tool to be used: tasks were to be assigned to him, but he was to have no influence on important decisions. The primary, directing influence

was to be exerted by proletarian writers. This attitude is well illustrated by the following statement by Lelevich, one of the critics of the group:

It is essential to review our attitude to the petty bourgeois fellow-travellers Only when the basic commanding heights are in the hands of the proletariat and its party, will the Ivanovs and the Nikitins be able to do their work of disorganizing the consciousness of our opponents.¹

It is not hard to understand why practically everybody who was anybody in Russian literature came in for a scolding. Pil'niak and Vsevolod Ivanov were criticized for their conception of the Revolution as an anarchical peasant uprising. A. N. Tolstoi was attacked for his nationalism. Akhmatova and Zamiatin, who did not accept the Revolution but withdrew into "their inner selves alone", were openly accused of being counter-revolutionary.

Equally damning accusations were hurled against Communists who disagreed with the views advanced by the group. One must admire the courage of the Onguardists, who attacked people quite high in the Soviet hierarchy. Trotskii, before his fall, and Bukharin, at the point of his greatest power, came out openly against the Onguardists without effecting any profound changes in their views. It may legitimately be asked what political support the Onguardists had. Unfortunately neither the contemporary material, nor material written after the liquidation of the movement in 1932 throws any light on this question.

In reviewing the works of individual authors the members of the group were consistent with their theoretical views: they applied what they considered dialectical materialism, to criticism of works of art. They did not admit of any limitations,

1. As quoted in A. Voronskii, "Iskústvo kak poznanie zhizni", Krasnaia Nov', No. 15 (5), (Moscow, 1923), p. 373.

The expression "basic heights", though a poor metaphor, is very significant as it is taken from the Party resolution promulgating the NEP. The resolution referred to the "commanding heights" when speaking of the heavy industries which were to remain in the hands of the state.

nor were they willing to face the rather obvious fact that Marxist art criticism was still in a very early stage of development, and was, therefore, a rather unreliable tool.

Their own criticism is the best proof of the above statement. In judging a book the critics of the group quite often resorted to criteria such as the class origin of the author, the number of times patently revolutionary sentiments were voiced in the work, or what people whose allegiance to Communism was beyond doubt thought of a book. Feeling that their hearts were pure, they frequently used their own ideas of what was beneficial to the Revolution as the basic standard of judgment.

We must not be surprised, therefore, if we find a reviewer criticizing Red Virgin Soil for publishing writers like Gor'kii, Leonov, and Babel', because the latter were also published by the "reactionary" Russian Contemporary (Russkii sovremennik). The apparent reasoning of the critic is the very common, but unsupportable "what my enemy considers good, can have no value for me."¹

In discussing the work of Akhmatova, Lelevich states that it is useless to the proletariat because it reflects an aristocrat's view of the world. To support his contention, Lelevich, being a little more sophisticated, does not simply state that Akhmatova was born in a noble family, rather does he cite the following three motives in her poems: a) complete absence of themes having social significance and a concentration on her own personal world, b) her mysticism and religiosity, c) the eroticism of many of her poems.

. . . . the dividing of her time between prayer and amatory passions, is it not typical of a representative of the aristoi?

Only as a result of complete estrangement from productive labor and social activities can there develop this concentration of all of one's emotions and thoughts on eroticism.²

1. N. Bakaev, Review of Krasnaia nov' No. 3 (20), Oktiabr' No. 2 (Moscow, 1924), p. 214.

2. G. Lelevich, "Anna Akhmatova", Na postu, No. 2-3 (Moscow, 1923) col. 186.

Lelevich, like many other Marxists, demands that the author have a positive view of life and love, and he cannot accept Akhmatova's anguish-filled love poems:

The love of Akhmatova is filled with pain and suffering, not only and not primarily because it is not returned, but because it is saturated with perverse conceit (nadlom --?) and with neurasthenia, all attributes of a refined, fin de siecle noble woman.¹

To what extremes such an attitude can lead is vividly illustrated by the famous review of Babel's Horse Army (Konarmia) by Marshal Budennyi, the leader of this army. Babel' was a member of the Serapion Brotherhood, a petty bourgeois by descent and one of the most successful of the writers championed by Voronskii. Marshal Budennyi was mobilized to prove that Babel' 's book was a libel on the heroes of the Red Army. Budennyi wrote:

Being by nature insignificant and ideologically foreign to us, he (Babel') did not notice its (the Cavalry Army's) gigantic battles. Citizen Babel' tells us old wives' gossip about the Cavalry Army, he pokes his nose into old wives' trash and dirty linen; like an old woman he tells us with terror that somewhere a hungry Red Army soldier took a piece of bread and chicken; he fabricates all kinds of wild tales, heaps dirt on its Communist commanders, has dream-phantasies and simply lies. The loud title, apparently, was needed by the author to stupefy the reader into believing the old tales that our revolution was not made by a class which had matured to a recognition of its class interests and to the immediate struggle for the state power, but by a gang of robbers, bandits and prostitutes, who have grabbed that power by superior force and by effrontery.

This is the old song of Messrs. Suvorin, Miliukov, Denikin, etc., who in their time yelled, wrote and whispered until they were hoarse about the coarse, the frantic, the stinking, the hateful and the muzhik-like (in the Revolution), but who have since understood the stupidity of it all and have stopped it²

This colorful bit of the Marshal's dissatisfaction with Babel' was printed as an essay of serious literary criticism. That the Marshal hardly discussed the literary merits, but instead concentrated on calling Babel' names and on making his writing look ridiculous and ominously counter-revolutionary, apparently disturbed the editors but little, for they had decided that Babel', the fellow-traveller, was harmful to the Revolution.

1. ibid., col. 187.

2. S. Budennyi, "Babizm Babelia iz 'Krasnoi novi'", Oktiabr' No. 3 (Moscow, 1924), p. 186.

CHAPTER III

THE PARTY DEBATES LITERATURE

The first issue of the review On Guard was received with unfavorable articles in most of the important journals of the period. Particularly sharp attacks were published in the most important literary periodicals of the time Press and Revolution (Pechat' i revoliutsiia), edited by Polonskii, and Red Virgin Soil (Krasnaia nov'), edited by Voronskii. The succeeding issues of On Guard contained even sharper attacks, to which the other journals reacted in kind.

The ever-increasing acerbity of the campaign finally forced a showdown in the Party itself. In the spring of 1924 the press section of the Central Committee of the Party organized a debate on the policy of the Party in matters of literature. In this debate, which continued until the summer of 1925, almost all the important personalities of the period participated. Their attitudes varied as much as their personalities, and the freedom in which the debate was conducted permitted an airing of all shades of opinion. It is, perhaps, a unique instance in history where statesmen and politicians discuss ably and earnestly problems of literature and reflects the high intellectual caliber of the men who made the Revolution. It is, perhaps, indicative of the change which the Soviet state has undergone in the last twenty years that no member of the present regime participated in the debate.

Trotskii's Views

Trotskii's views on literature are important not only because they exerted some influence on the official policies of the Party, but also because they reflect Trotskii's political philosophy. These views are expounded in a collection of essays entitled Literature and Revolution.

Trotsky defines culture as "the organic aggregate of knowledge and skills which characterizes an entire society or, at least, its ruling class."¹ From this broad definition of culture Trotsky proceeds to argue that a proletarian culture is a logical impossibility:

The setting up of a proletarian art and of a proletarian literature in opposition to a bourgeois art and a bourgeois literature is radically wrong. The former will never exist at all, since a proletarian regime is temporary and transitory. The historical significance and moral greatness of the proletarian revolution lie in the fact that it lays the foundation for a class-less culture, for the first genuinely universal culture.²

He emphasizes the fact that it took the bourgeoisie several centuries to develop their culture, that it took even more time for slave holders (Egypt, Greece, Rome) to develop their genuine class culture. The dictatorship of the proletariat is ~~not~~ supposed to last but a few decades, until the world revolution will have made a transition to communism and a class-less society possible. In the brief period of a few decades, even in a century, the proletariat, which conquered political power without even the beginnings of a culture of its own (in the sense in which the bourgeoisie had begun to create a culture of its own even before the French Revolution secured its dominion politically and economically), will not be able to create this culture ex nihilo.

The author warns against considering the work of a few writers of proletarian extraction or of Communist conviction as proletarian literature. He points to the fact that Bezymenskii (a proletarian poet who attracted quite a bit of attention at the time) would be impossible without the non-proletarian poetry of Maiakovskii, Pil'niak, and Pasternak, and that almost all of the writings of the proletarian writers of the period are in idioms and styles which were developed in pre-revolutionary days.

As all events of such major importance, the Revolution and the dictatorship of the proletariat will affect the culture of the world. However this is not to be

1. L.D. Trotsky, Literatura i revoliutsiia, (2d ed., Moscow, 1924), p. 152.

2. ibid., p. 11.

equated with the creation of a proletarian culture.

In his discussion of the crisis through which proletarian literature was passing after the adoption of the NEP, Trotskii rejects the usual explanations about the impact of the revived bourgeois ideology upon proletarian poets:

The crux in the matter lies in the fact that in the pre-revolutionary period and in the early days of the Revolution proletarian poets regarded verse making not as an art which has its own laws, but rather as one of the means to complain about their hard lot or to give expression to their revolutionary spirit. Proletarian poets have approached poetry as art and as mastery only in the last few years, when the tensions of the Civil War have decreased. It is now that it has become apparent that in the sphere of art the proletariat has as yet not created its own cultural medium, while the bourgeoisie has such a medium regardless of whether it is good or poor.¹

Because of this fact Trotskii advocates a great deal of freedom for the so-called fellow-travellers of the Revolution; i.e. artists who accept the Revolution with reservations.

Our policy in matters of the art of the transition period can and should be directed towards facilitating for the various artistic groups and tendencies which stand on the (ideological) soil of the Revolution, a genuine assimilation of its historical meaning and, while setting up for all of them the categorical criterion: for the Revolution or against the Revolution, permit them full freedom in the sphere of artistic self-determination.²

It must be emphasized here that Trotskii never advocated unconditional freedom of artistic creation. To him "the good of the Revolution was the highest law", and he would not tolerate any expression of opinions which might be counter-revolutionary:

It was in this sense that I wrote in my book that together with a flexible and far-sighted policy in the field of art, we absolutely need a decisive and severe, but, of course, not petty, censorship.³

In the discussions on the policy of the Party in matters of literature, Trotskii severely attacked the On Guard group.⁴ The speech of Trotskii is probably the most

1. ibid., p. 154.

2. ibid., p. 11.

3. ibid., p. 206 footnote.

4. It is an irony of fate that the people against whom Trotskii inveighed here were later accused of being Trotskii-ites.

brilliant piece of writing on the whole subject of proletarian culture. Its biting polemic tone, Trotskii's mastery of debating technique, his brilliant wit and scathing tongue make the speech almost a literary masterpiece.

In the speech Trotskii develops approximately the same ideas as in his essays cited above. He censures the Onguardists for their hounding of all fellow-travellers, from Maiakovskii to Pil'niak. He accuses them of inconsistency and points out that they praised his views on the fellow-travellers at the time when his essays were serialized in Pravda and only changed their evaluation when they read his conclusions. He attacks their views on the place of the classics as a lifeless and vulgar conception of Marxist views. He defends Voronskii against the charges of On Guard. In his last sentences he rejects all claims for official recognition:

You want the Party to adopt your little artistic factory officially in the name of the class. You think that having planted a kidney-bean in a flower pot, you have become capable of growing the tree of proletarian literature. On that road we shall not embark. From a kidney-bean no tree can ever grow.¹

Voronskii's Views

Voronskii, who was probably the most influential personality in Soviet literary life during the first decade after the Revolution, was the chief opponent of the Onguardists. In his work as an editor he showed that his main interest was in re-establishing the quality of Russian literature. Although a Communist of fairly long standing in the Party, he was not primarily interested in political problems. Despite the fact that his name is often coupled with that of Trotskii, he seems to have been a moderate man whose natural inclinations were towards peaceful activities rather than towards revolutionary ventures.

Voronskii's artistic theory is contained in the article "Art as Perception of Life, and Contemporaneity", where he gives the following definition of art:

1. ibid., p. 213. (Speech quoted in full in L.D. Trotskii, Literatura i revoliutsiia, (2d ed., Moscow, 1924), pp. 196-213).

Art is above all perception (poznanie) of life. Art is not an arbitrary play of phantasy, of feelings, of states of mind; art is not solely an expression of the subjective emotions and experiences of the poet; art does not aim primarily at awakening "good sentiments" in the reader. Art has the same subject as science: life, reality. But science analyzes, while art synthesizes; science is abstract, art is concrete; science appeals to man's reason, art to his sensual nature. Science perceives life with the aid of concepts, art -- with the aid of images in the form of live sensual contemplation.¹

However that does not mean that the artist copies life. Rather does he select from life those aspects which are significant and presents to us a reality which resembles "the truth more closely than the most real actuality."²

Like all Marxists Voronskii accepts the theory of the class nature of art. However, he sees in every work of art two aspects: one, subjective, determined by the psychology and personality of the author, which in turn is the product of his class environment and of the explicit or implicit demands made upon the artist by the ruling class of his time; the other, the objective aspect, is implicit in Voronskii's conception of art as perception of life. Life, reality, is the basis of all art; therefore, there can exist no art which lacks an objective element.

The task of the Marxist critic is to separate the subjective element, which usually has no value for the proletariat, from the objective aspect of a work of art, from its all-human, eternal aspect.

According to Voronskii Plekhanov, who was then the commonly accepted authority on Marxist literary criticism, did just that. He first would determine the "sociological equivalent" of a work of art; i.e., he would determine on the basis of what features of the psychology of a class a work of art matured; and to what extent this basis (the thoughts, emotions, ideas, attitudes which shaped the psychology of the artist) corresponds to the needs of society as a whole at a particular point in time. (The needs of society as a whole are synonymous with the needs of its most progressive and vital class.) However, Plekhanov realized that this was not enough and did not content himself with finding the "sociological equivalent", he always gave an esthetic

1. A. Voronskii, "Iskusstvo, kak poznanie zhizni, i sovremennost'", Krasnaia nov', No. 15 (5), (Moscow, 1923), p. 349.

2. ibid., p. 350.

analysis as well.

To evaluate an artistic creation esthetically means to determine to what extent the content corresponds to objective artistic truth; for, inasmuch as the artist reasons in images, the images must be truthful; i.e. correspond to the nature of what is represented. In this lies the perfection, the beautiful in the work of an artist. A false idea, a false content cannot find a perfect form; i.e. it cannot deeply captivate us in an esthetic sense, it cannot "infect" us¹

The logical conclusion which Voronskii drew from this theory (it would probably be more correct to say that the theory was developed as a justification for his editorial policies) was that it was not necessary to be an orthodox Communist of proletarian extraction in order to produce great art of value to the new ruling class -- the proletariat. It is the universal element in the writings of the fellow-travellers which makes them of value to the proletariat. Since truth is the criterion for greatness in art, and since truth is on the side of the Revolution great art must, of necessity, be of value to the Revolution.

On similar grounds Voronskii rejects the subordination of art to a definite political purpose. While at times it may be necessary for an artist to write political propaganda, his main task is to perceive life. His task in perceiving life is like that of the scientist whose work has often no direct connection with the everyday needs of mankind, but who, nevertheless, contributes to the happiness of all men. To demand that artists concentrate on writing "agitki" (political propaganda verse) -- as the Futurists did -- would be like demanding that Pasteur leave his laboratory and, instead of conducting his experiments, become a general practitioner in an outlying district.

In many respects these views harmonize with the views of Trotskii on literature. Indeed Voronskii openly admitted his agreement with Trotskii. In his contribution to the debate on the policy of the Party in matters of literature² Voronskii repeated

1. ibid., p. 365.

2. "O proletarskom iskusstve i o khudozhestvennoi politike nashei partii", Krasnaia nov', No. 17 (7), (Moscow, 1923), pp. 257-276.

Trotskii's contention that a proletarian culture is a logical impossibility. Like the latter he advocated a large measure of creative freedom for fellow-travellers and emphasized the importance of raising the general level of culture in Russia, rather than creating a new culture.

In the accepted style of the Party Voronskii enlists the authority of Lenin on his side. He quotes the following passage from Lenin's article "Better Less, but Better":

We are inclined to be permeated with this quality (unbelief and skepticism - A. Voronskii) in regard to those who too much and too easily sound off, for example, about "proletarian culture". As a start bourgeois culture would be quite enough for us, for the beginning we could do without especially extreme types of pre-bourgeois cultures; i.e. of bureaucrat and feudal cultures. In matters of culture hurry and extremes are worse than anything else. This many of our young literateurs and Communists would do well to ponder over (literally "to wind into their mustaches" - M.H.)¹

Finally we must consider Voronskii's views on censorship. It is a Communist doctrine which nobody in the Party seems ever to have questioned openly that censorship of the media of communication of ideas is essential to the success of the dictatorship of the proletariat. While subscribing to this tenet, Voronskii came out against the excesses of the Glavlit, the organ of censorship. As a criterion for the censors Voronskii proposed the following principle which closely resembles Trotskii's formula on creative freedom for the fellow-travellers:

(The censors) ought to limit themselves to one demand: that the piece be not counter-revolutionary, and they should not see this counter-revolutionary tendency in single deviations of the writer, or in his picturing the dark side of Soviet life.²

This moderate view prevailed for a time. With the end of the struggle between Stalin and Trotskii, the question of political loyalty to the regime became again a central one. The critical conditions under which the first Five Year Plan was inaugurated and executed still further exacerbated it. It will, therefore, not surprise many that by 1928 the views of Voronskii were considered counter-revolutionary

1. ibid., p. 263.

2. ibid., p. 275.

and that Voronskii was expelled from the Party and exiled to Siberia. He returned to Moscow in 1930 and was re-admitted into the Party. Although he continued to write and publish, he never regained his prominent position in Soviet letters.

Bukharin's Views

The peculiar balance of power prevailing at that time made Bukharin one of the most influential people in the Soviet government. It was only by an alliance with Bukharin and Rykov that Stalin was able to defeat Trotskii. It is, therefore, no surprise that Bukharin's views profoundly influenced the final formulation of the policy of the Party.

As is well-known Bukharin held that the transition period from capitalism to a class-less society was to last a long time. Accordingly he felt that a specifically proletarian culture might develop, and that everything should be done to foster it. However, he did not see eye to eye with the On-guardists in whose violent demands for hegemony he apparently saw a doctrine resembling Trotskii's "permanent Revolution".

In a speech made at a meeting of the Central Committee Bukharin departed from the customary pattern of Soviet orators: he stated that Lenin did not share his views that a proletarian culture might develop in Russia.¹ Consequently the On-guardists were using Lenin's name in vain.

According to Bukharin Trotskii was wrong in his belief that the transition period would be short. Social forms evolve slowly, and the Revolution can accelerate this change only to a very limited degree.

Bukharin then develops a rather ingenious explanation for Lenin's differences with him. Bukharin believes that Lenin held this view because he feared Communist arrogance might develop and be fatal to the prospects of the Revolution:

1. Cf. p. 11 supra.

. . . . if we talk about it (proletarian culture - M.H.) now, yell about it and attract to it general attention, we would ruin the thing. The time has not come yet. Now we must teach the three "R"s, teach people to wash their hands, etc.¹

Next Bukharin analyzes the platform of the October group. He approves of their statements that art is a weapon in the class struggle and that art cannot be neutral in a class society. However, he disagrees sharply with the conclusions which the group draws from these premises, namely that it is reactionary to speak of peaceful cooperation and competition of various ideological groups in literature. This is an error which was committed because the framers of the platform forget that

. . . . our society has two planes of friction -- an internal one and an external. Externally it stands face to face with the bourgeois world, and there the class struggle becomes ever shaper. But internally, how should one pose the question? Here there is a lack of understanding of the circumstance that inside our country our policy does not at all follow a line which would start a class struggle, but, quite the contrary, from a certain point of view it tends towards a softening (of the class struggle. - M.H.)²

By its struggle in the Revolution the proletariat has conquered the right to political hegemony. It has as yet not won this right in the cultural field. It must win this right in a free competition with other groups, whom it will try to "switch to the rails of socialism". This applies to fellow-travellers as well as to the peasantry. Only obviously hopeless cases, e.g. "Black Hundreds", should be expelled.

(A proletarian art can be achieved) only if the Party does not squeeze everybody into one fist, but rather provides the opportunity for competition

. . . . it is necessary to state quite clearly, without mentioning individuals and personalities, that the struggle against Communist arrogance must now become the central one, and on this front we must be merciless. We must go on record here that we are in favor of a maximum of competition. Why do you think that the Central Committee should

1. N. Bukharin, "Proletariat i voprosy khudozhestvennoi politiki", Krasnaia nov', No. 4, (Moscow, 1925), p. 265.

2. ibid., p. 266.

attach itself to any single organization? Let there be a thousand organizations, two thousand organizations; let there exist besides MAPP and VAPP as many organizations and circles as want to¹

Polonskii's Views

Viacheslav Polonskii was the editor of the most important contemporary literary review Press and Revolution (Pechat' i revoliutsiia) and of one of the "fat" journals New World (Novyi mir). He seems to have enjoyed the confidence of persons high in the Party hierarchy as his articles on literary questions appeared regularly in Pravda and Izvestiia. He was also the literary editor of the Great Soviet Encyclopedia.

Polonskii tried to establish a basis upon which the conflicting tendencies could settle their differences. Like all peace-makers he was not loved by either side and earned little gratitude for his efforts. The Onguardists attacked his eclecticism, which in Russia has become a derogatory term since Lenin fought the eclectics in the ranks of the early Marxists.

Polonskii's views were very close to those of Lunacharskii, who was a contributing editor of Press and Revolution. I have chosen to discuss Polonskii rather than Lunacharskii, because the latter seems to me to have been more influenced by considerations other than literary. This lack of consistency is shown particularly clearly in Lunacharskii's sudden reversal of his previously negative attitude towards the theories of the Onguardists in 1928.

Indeed Polonskii's views must be termed eclectic. They are an attempt to establish a synthesis between the views of Voronskii and those of Lelevich, who at that time (1923-1925) was the leading ideologist of the Onguardists. Polonskii criticized Voronskii's view of art as a perception of life as too narrow. He criticized Lelevich's formula of art as a means for the systematization and socialization

1. ibid., p. 272.

of feelings as too broad. According to Polonskii, Voronskii's formula does not take into consideration the fact that art is also a medium of expression for individuals and classes, while Lelevich's definition of art would include things which are very obviously not art; e.g. newspaper articles.

Polonskii defines art as follows: "Art is a means for the systematization of emotions in images. It is at the same time a tool of class self-perception."¹

Polonskii then develops a rather curious theory about the emotional infectiousness of art. A class-conscious proletarian will be influenced only by those features of a work of art which are in agreement with his Weltanschauung and will reject those which are harmful to the class. To support this thesis he quotes Mehring: "The proletariat will not and cannot be moved by art which is in sharp contradiction to all its (the proletariat's - M.H.) emotions and thoughts, to everything which is most dear to it in life!"²

He then points out the obvious fact that the men who made the Revolution were brought up on Pushkin, Tolstoi, etc., none of whom were proletarian writers. This, however, did not affect the class-consciousness of people like Lenin.

It is rather obvious that this theory is a rationalization of Polonskii's desire to give artists greater creative freedom. However, he does not come out for an abolition of censorship, for in Russia the masses are not yet class-conscious and could be swayed by the writings of non-proletarian authors.³ Nonetheless the censorship should not deal with literature except in cases of clearly counter-revolutionary propaganda. The task of dealing with ideological differences should be entrusted to Marxist literary criticism, which in the hands of skilled men⁴ can be wielded for the

1. V. Polonskii, "K voprosu o nashikh literaturnykh raznoglasiiakh", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 4 (Moscow, 1925), p. 60.

2. ibid., p. 65.

3. Polonskii accepts, but with reservations, the view that the class of a writer determines his ideology. Cf. op. cit.

4. Polonskii shows rather convincingly that the Onguardists are very poor critics, even if their theories be accepted as correct. Cf. op. cit.

good of the state.

Polonskii believes that a proletarian culture will develop and recommends that everything be done to foster it: "The Party and the government must supply proletarian writers with all that is necessary for them to achieve victory in the literary struggle; however, that victory they must win themselves!"¹

1. V. Polonskii, op. cit., p. 70.

CHAPTER IV

THE PARTY "DECIDES"

Conditions in NEP Russia

While conditions in Russia had improved considerably if compared to the night-marish days of the Civil War, they left a great deal to be desired. During the NEP there existed in Russia private as well as governmental publishing houses. Very few publishing houses, whether private or public, could provide the writers with decent incomes. The private publishers were too harrassed by various restrictions and conscious of the fact that their enterprises would soon be taken over by the state, to give any thought to anything except their own profits. Official publishing houses suffered from lack of appropriations and of skilled personnel. The contemporary reviews are full of letters by writers complaining about unreturned manuscripts, long waiting periods before payment was made on accepted material. Plagiarism was rampant. As well-known a writer as A. N. Tolstoi was found guilty of "careless and uncomradely" use of material submitted to him.¹ The fact that Russia had no trade agreements with Western nations and did not belong to the international copyright convention deprived Russian writers from royalties on books published abroad in the original or in translations. Conditions improved somewhat after the conclusion of the Rapallo agreement with Germany in 1922.

Although an official censorship (Glavlit) was established in 1922² it was not very oppressive. From 1922 to 1929 the yearly percentage of books rejected never

1. For report of the trial see Na literaturnom postu, No. 5-6 (Moscow, 1927), p. 110.

2. Literaturnaia entsiklopediia (Moscow, 1930), II, col. 545.

exceeded 1 per cent of the total manuscripts submitted.¹ It is significant that Zamiatin and Bulgakov, though attacked as counter-revolutionary by Marxist critics, continued to publish and that the Moscow Art Theatre produced Bulgakov's controversial play The Days of the Turbins.

If we compare the stenographic reports of the speeches of Trotskii and Bukharin, which are interspersed with remarks of people who disagreed with the speakers, and the apparently uninhibited way in which various and sundry periodicals attacked individuals very high in the councils of the Party (though never the Party itself) with the unanimous acceptance with which Zhdanov's criticisms of Soviet literature (August, 1946) and of Soviet philosophy (June, 1947) were received by the Soviet press, we must conclude that on these subjects freedom of expression has been severely restricted in the Soviet Union since then.

The Resolution of the Press Section

In May of 1924 the division for agitation and propaganda of the Central Committee of the Communist Party called a conference at which the problems of literature were discussed. Practically all the important literary personalities participated in the debate. The debate was very heated² and at the end of the conference Iakovlev³ proposed a resolution which the conference adopted.

The resolution was a sharp rebuke to the proponents of hegemony of proletarian literature. It was the first in a series of defeats suffered by the On Guard group, which culminated in the closing of their review.

Although the resolution stated that the peasant and worker correspondents should be regarded as the reserves from which the future writers will come and that these groups be given special assistance, it did not advocate giving supremacy to these groups as advocated by the Onguardists. In very unequivocal terms the resolution

1. Literaturnaia entsiklopediia, (Moscow, 1930), II, col. 545.

2. I was unable to locate a detailed report on the proceedings. Trotskii's speech (cf. pp. 31-f.) and the brief notices in contemporary periodicals indicate, however, that passions ran quite high.

3. Cf. p 11 supra.

condemned the group and their tactics:

3. The conference considers essential the continuation of the former line of the Party in regard to the so-called fellow-travellers. Systematic support of the more gifted of them, who are being educated in the school of comradely cooperation with Communists, is necessary. The methods which the review On Guard employs in its struggle with the fellow-travellers repel talented writers from the Party and from the Soviet power. At the same time they impede the actual growth of proletarian writers by substituting a cavilling criticism of the fellow-travellers for serious artistic and political self-development. Simultaneously a more consistent organization of Party (literary) criticism is necessary which would select and support talented Soviet writers as well as point out their mistakes caused by an insufficient understanding of the Soviet system and in this manner would push them towards an overcoming of their bourgeois prejudices.¹

The resolution condemns clannishness and bohemianism in various literary circles and names the Smiths and the Onguardists as examples of this shortcoming. The conference recorded its concern over the low quality of provincial newspapers.

In the final paragraph of the resolution the conference rejects all claims for official recognition. In this the resolution follows a precedent set by Lunacharskii in the first year of the Soviet state's existence.²

6. The conference considers that no single literary tendency, school or group can or should step forth in the name of the Party. The conference recognizes as desirable the organization of regular conferences between writers and Communist critics³

The thirteenth Conference of the Communist Party, which met a few weeks after the adoption of the resolution by the press section of the Central Committee, incorporated almost the entire resolution in its own resolution on matters of the press. Thereby the rebuke administered to the Onguardists had been sanctioned by the highest authority in the country.

1. "KHronika", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 3 (Moscow, 1924), p. 288.

2. Cf. p. 5 supra.

3. "KHronika", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 3 (Moscow, 1924), p. 288.

The Resolution of the Central Committee of 1925

Despite the fact that a conference of the Party had passed a resolution censuring the Onguardists, the latter continued their struggle undaunted. In the spring of 1925 the Central Committee held another conference in which the problems of literature were threshed out anew. The resolution adopted after this debate differs in some details from that adopted by the press section. These differences are due to the great changes which the Soviet system was undergoing just at that time.

By the spring of 1925 the influence of Trotskii had greatly decreased, and the struggle for supremacy in the Party was in full swing. Stalin had just parted company with Zinov'ev and Kamenev over the question of the continuation of the NEP and had joined with Bukharin and Rykov to form a triumvirate which was to rule Russia for several years. The Lenin recruitment of new Party members was taking place at this time. The economic conditions inside the country were somewhat improved. A number of Western nations had recognized the Soviets diplomatically, However, internally the Party was split over the continuance of the NEP, with Trotskii advocating its immediate abolition, and Bukharin -- its indefinite extension.

On the literary scene the fellow-travellers still held the center of interest. The first important works of fiction started to appear; e.g. Leonid Leonov's The Badgers (1925), Fedin's Cities and Years (1924), Ehrenburg's Julio Jurenito (1921), and Babel's Horse Army (1924). This was also the time of the great Esenin vogue, which alarmed authorities to the extent of ordering a general attack upon "Eseninism" as an ideology foreign and hostile to the proletariat. Proletarian writers won their first laurels. Libedinskii's A Week (1922) and The Commissars (1923) and Furmanov's Chapaev (1923) proved to those who were eager to be convinced that a proletarian literature could develop.

The sharp rebuke given by the Party to the Onguardists engendered a certain amount of internal opposition to the leadership of the group. The diaries of the writer Furmanov, who was the secretary of MAPP, contain a number of entries which are highly critical of the policies of Lelevich, Rodov and Vardin.

Furmanov charged that the latter were devoting too much time to non-literary pursuits: e.g. playing politics, arguing about administrative matters, and attacking people holding divergent views. This as well as the tone of their writings had alienated the Party as a whole, and Party members individually from the cause of proletarian literature.¹

Despite the claims of later Soviet publications that Furmanov "saw through the treacherous machinations of the Trotskii-ite leadership of the Onguardists", no official documents have been published in which Furmanov advocated changes in the basic policies of the group. As secretary of the Moscow association he could have easily introduced resolutions censuring the Lelevich group or fought by other, more effective means than entries in a personal journal. As far as I was able to ascertain there was no open struggle in the group until after the adoption of the resolution on literature by the Central Committee in 1925. This fact is even more significant if we realize that the conditions prevailing at the time were eminently favorable for an open struggle against the leadership.

The main reason for the absence of internal opposition to the leadership is probably to be sought in the Communist discipline which required that a policy once adopted had to be supported by all members regardless of their previous views. Furmanov, who was one of the founders of the October group, probably observed the discipline as a matter of course.

1. Cf. quotations from Furmanov's diaries first published in Oktiabr' (Moscow, 1937), No. 6, in "KHronika sovetskoi literatury za 20 let", Literaturnyi kritik, No. 12, (Moscow, 1937), p. 173.

The resolution of 1925 is to a certain extent a compromise between the opposing views. While the resolution sharply condemns the practices of the Onguard group and affirms the rights of the fellow-travellers, it does not mention the group by name as the earlier resolutions had done. Like the other resolutions it does not deny the possibility of a proletarian culture developing in Russia, nor does it reject the claims of proletarian writers for special support by organs of the government and the Party.

The resolution points out that the rise in the material prosperity of the masses in recent times has brought with it an increased demand for culture. This demand is a further step on the road towards the Communist society. A part of the growing mass culture is the new proletarian and peasant literature.

The economic contradictions of the NEP must and do have influence on contemporary literature. The class struggle is reflected in literature as well as in other spheres of Soviet life and must be carried on with the same resoluteness there as elsewhere: "In a class society there is no and there cannot be a neutral art; although the class nature of art in general and of literature in particular expresses itself in forms which are infinitely more varied than those of politics, for instance."¹

Attention is also called to the fact that since the establishment of the dictatorship of the proletariat the character of the class struggle within the country has radically changed. The problem now is how to live with the peasantry, while slowly transforming it; how to permit a certain amount of collaboration with the bourgeoisie, while attempting slowly to force it out completely; how to employ the technical and other skills of the intelligentsia, while winning it away from the bourgeoisie.²

1. Complete resolution quoted in "Obozrenie iskusstva i literatury", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 5-6 (Moscow, 1925), p. 226.

2. Note how closely the resolution follows the views of Bukharin, cf. pp. 38-39 supra.

The proletariat must create its own culture: its own psychology, biology as well as literature based in dialectical materialism. In the past, under the rule of and in slavery to the bourgeoisie, the proletariat did not have the opportunity to solve the problems of science and art in its own fashion. It, therefore, does not have as yet "a specific answer to all problems concerning artistic form".¹

Hegemony in literature belongs to the proletarian writers. Since this hegemony is as yet not a fact, the Party must help proletarian writers "to earn for themselves the historic right to this hegemony".

10. In regard to the "fellow-travellers" it is essential to remember: 1) their differentiation, 2) the importance of many of them as qualified "specialists" of literary technique, 3) the existence of vacillations in this group of writers. The general directive in their case must be the directive of tactfulness and consideration; i.e., that approach which will guarantee their most rapid transition to the side of the Communist ideology. Rejecting anti-proletarian and anti-revolutionary elements (now completely insignificant), struggling with growth of a neo-bourgeois ideology among a part of the "fellow-travellers" of the "change-of-guard" variety, the Party must behave tolerantly to the transitory ideological forms, patiently helping them (the fellow-travellers - M.H.) to out-live these unavoidably numerous forms in the process of increasingly closer comradely cooperation with the cultural forces of Communism.²

While aiding proletarian writers in all possible ways, the Party must combat the growth of "Communist arrogance" (Komchvanstvo) among them. The Party must fight an indiscriminate debunking attitude towards the art of the past. At the same time a struggle must be waged against those who fail to realize the importance of the achievement of proletarian hegemony in literature. It must not permit the development of a "hot-house" variety of proletarian literature. It is the duty of Communist literary criticism to struggle with all deviations from the correct line of the Party. However, this work must be done tactfully and patiently; it must be on a high intellectual level and completely devoid of "semi-literate Communist conceit".

1. "Obozrenie iskusstv i literatury", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 5-6 (Moscow, 1925), p. 227.

2. ibid.

13. Discerning infallibly the social class content of literary tendencies, the Party cannot commit itself to support any single movement in the sphere of literary form. Although giving leadership to literature as a whole, the Party can no more support any one literary factionthan it can decide by resolution the question of the future shape of the family Everything leads one to suppose that a style appropriate for our epoch will be created; however it will be created by other methods (than a Party resolution -- M.H.). . . . All attempts to commit the Party in this matter in the present stage of cultural development of the country must be rejected.

14. Therefore the Party must declare itself for free competition among the various groups and tendencies in this field. Any other solution of the question would be a bureaucratic pseudo-solution. It is similarly inadmissible that a legalized monopoly over literary publishing be granted to any one group or organization by a decree or a decision of the Party. While morally and materially assisting proletarian and proletarian-peasant literature and aiding "fellow-travellers" etc., the Party cannot give a monopoly to one group, not even to the most proletarian in its ideology: this step would be tantamount to destroying proletarian literature.

15. The Party must eradicate all attempts at incompetent and crudely administrative interference in matters of literature; the Party must attend to a careful selection of personnel in the organs which deal with matters of the press, in order to guarantee a correct, useful and tactful direction of our literature.¹

These three paragraphs are in essence a summary of the most serious charges brought against the Onguardists by their opponents. They are commonly regarded as the magna charta of Soviet literature, for they permitted rather wide ideological divergences among writers and rejected unequivocally demands for a narrow and inflexible definition of what constitutes ideologically acceptable literature.

The final paragraph of the resolution talks of the differing functions of the writer and of the critic, of the importance of developing the literatures of the national minorities and calls upon writers to utilize contemporary themes in their works.²

The Party must emphasize the necessity of creating a literature to serve the needs and the interests of the mass reader, the worker and the peasant. It is necessary to break more courageously and decisively with the prejudices of serfdom in literature and, while utilizing all the technical achievements of the old masters, to develop the literary form

1. ibid., p. 228.

2. Cf. p. 23 supra.

appropriate for our epoch and comprehensible to the millions.¹

Reactions to the Resolution

Among the immediate results of the resolution were the suspension of the review On Guard, an internal struggle in the group which resulted in a change of the leadership, albeit not of the ideology, and the formation of The Federation of Soviet Writers, which included practically all literary factions among its members.

In writers' circles the resolution provoked a great deal of optimism. It was felt that finally Soviet writers had been told the limits within which they could operate safely and that these limits were broad enough to permit proper growth of the writer's personality. Indeed the years 1925-1927 are perhaps the most fruitful years of Soviet literature, for in that period Sholokhov wrote his Silent Don, Olesha published Envy; Fadeyev -- The Rout, to mention but a few of the best works of the period. While the policy of the Party was not the sole cause of this flowering, it was doubtless a very important contributing factor.

A spirit of optimism and hopefulness pervaded most of the reactions of Russian authors to the resolution.

Andrei Belyi hailed the resolution as "flexible as well as humane".² Leonid Leonov praised it as scattering clouds very dangerous to the future development of the young Soviet literature. He continued:

The policy of attack and semi-administrative oppression and, at times, even of simple plotting against individuals as well as the ceaseless group quarrel, which was exhausting our common forces in vain, has been condemned by the Party I have no doubt that every honest, intelligent worker of our press will receive the resolution of the Central Committee on belles lettres with a feeling of great relief.³

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1. "Obozrenie iskusstv i literatury", Pechat' i revoliutsiia, No. 5-6 (Moscow, 1925), p. 229.
 2. "Otkliki russkikh pisatelei na rezoliutsiiu XII s'ezda RKP", Versty, No. 1 (Paris, 1926), p. 196.
 3. ibid, p. 198.

Victor Shklovskii, a critic of the formalist school, hoped that the resolution had "demobilized" the Onguardists, "who now can return to their literary work".¹

Pil'niak and Pasternak, though less optimistic about the resolution itself, saw in it a step in the right direction. Pil'niak said that upon his return to Moscow in the early fall of 1925 he was surprised to find that writers no longer spent all their time arguing about literature, but instead stayed in their rooms creating it.²

Aleksei N. Tolstoi thought that the resolution would end the fraternal strife among Russian writers. In line with his belief in the mission of Russia in the world, he wrote:

Just as unconditionally and inexorably as mankind will go through the revolution of the proletariat, so literature will inevitably come closer to the masses. But this process is long and complicated Upon us, Russian writers, falls a special responsibility: we are the first. Like Columbuses on battered caravels, we are striving across an unknown sea to a new land. After us ocean liners will come. Great artists shall come forth from the proletariat. But the trail shall be blazed by us.³

The somewhat equivocal tone of certain passages of the resolution as well as the fact that the resolution refrained from naming names, allowed members of the Onguard group to claim that their views had been upheld by the Party. It is, therefore, not surprising that we find Lelevich and Bezymenskii, two of the most important leaders of the Onguardists, joining in the general approval.

Lelevich claimed that the resolution was a definite rebuke to all Trotskii-ites, who denied that a proletarian literature would ever develop. He emphasized that the resolution affirmed the desire of the Party to aid proletarian writers in

1. ibid., p. 200.

2. ibid., p. 203.

3. ibid., p. 205.

winning literary hegemony, thus agreeing with the demands of his group. He explained the criticism of the tactics of "certain" groups as directed against excesses of "Communist arrogance".¹

Bezymenskii commented upon the "rejection of anti-proletarian and anti-revolutionary elements" by the resolution. He stated that this was what his group had done since its founding. Like Lelevich he emphasized the resolutions' condemnation of those who did not believe in a proletarian art's developing in Russia.

The resolution of the Central Committee supplies a platform for unification of proletarian and all genuinely revolutionary literature. By founding, together with a number of other groups, The Federation of Soviet Writers, VAPP has laid the foundation for such a unification.²

Despite these strained attempts at harmonizing the stinging criticism with the avowed policy of the Onguardists, the leadership could not maintain itself in power. Rodov, Lelevich, Bezymenskii and Vardin were soon forced out and replaced by men who were less identified with the propagation of the On Guard ideology and, therefore, less compromised. The new leadership claimed to have made the ideological changes demanded by the resolution, although its policies differed but little from those of their predecessors.

By March of 1926 they regained the authorization to issue their own review which bore the title On the Literary Guard (Na literaturnom postu) and the struggle which had seemed decided by the resolution began anew -- this time to end in temporary victory for the Onguardists.

1. ibid., p. 200.

2. ibid., p. 201.

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